

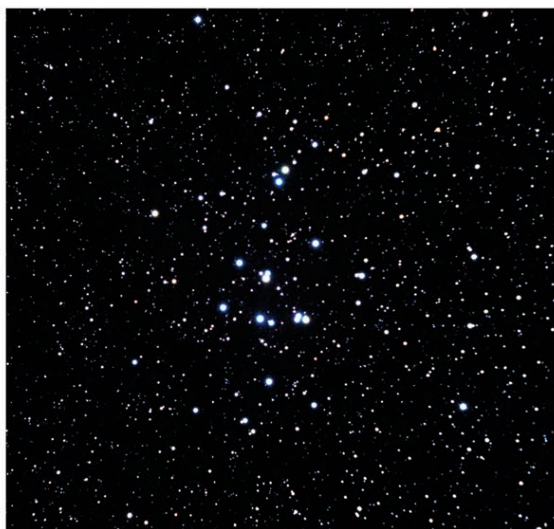
CANCER

THE CRAB

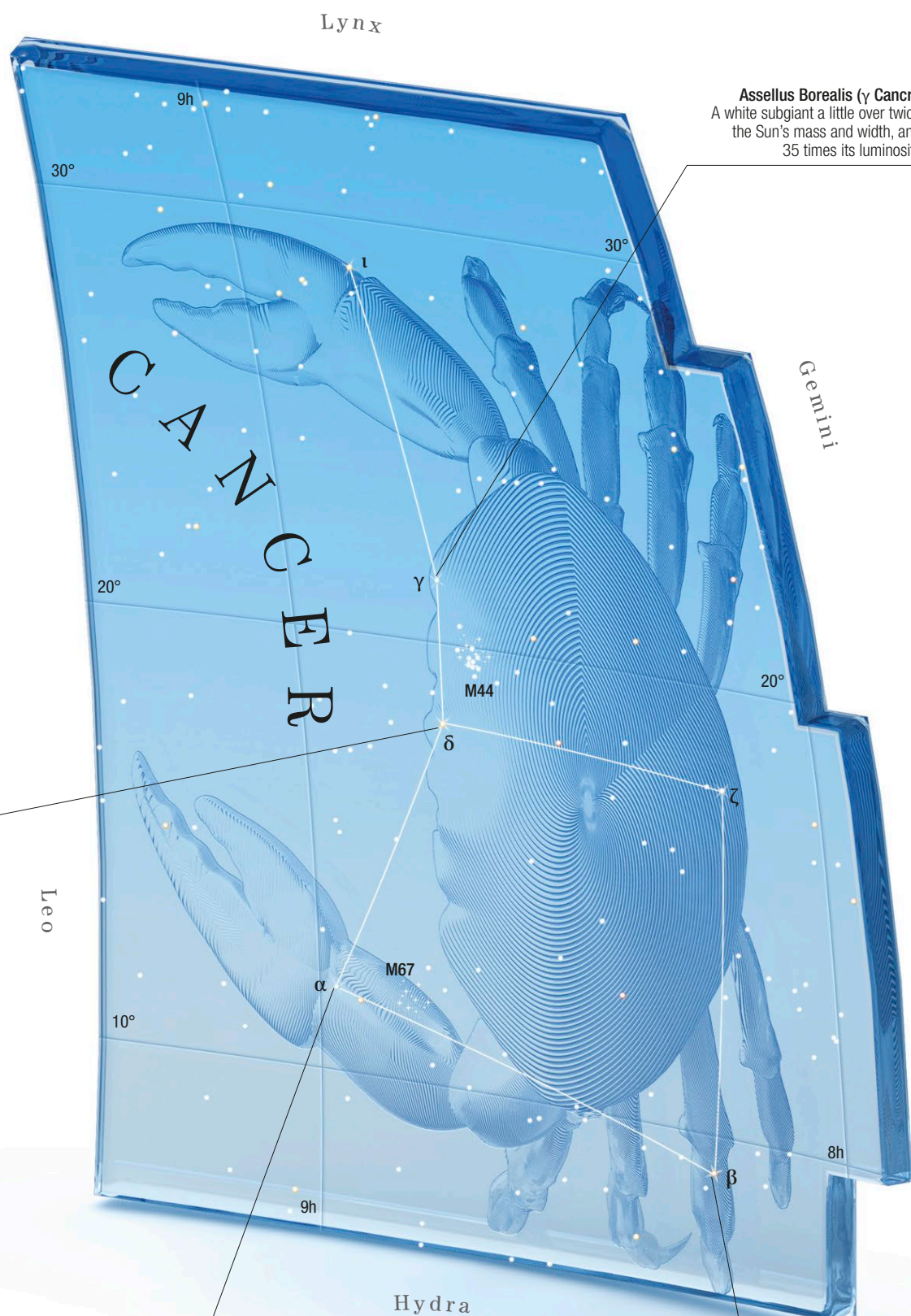
ALTHOUGH THE FAINTEST OF THE ZODIAC CONSTELLATIONS, CANCER IS EASY TO FIND BETWEEN THE BRIGHTER STARS OF LEO AND GEMINI.

Cancer represents the crab that attacked the hero Hercules as he fought the multi-headed monster Hydra. A square of stars form the body of the "crab," and the stars Alpha and Iota mark its claws. Alpha takes its name Acubens from the Arabic for claw. The names of the stars Assellus Borealis and Assellus Australis, the northern and southern ass, come from a different legend featuring a donkey. These stars lie on either side of the cluster M44 (also known as the Beehive Cluster), which is said to represent the donkey's manger. None of Cancer's stars is particularly bright, and the region is relatively barren. Iota is a yellow giant with a companion detectable with binoculars, and Acubens and Zeta are multiple stars.

Assellus Australis (δ Cancri)
An orange giant of magnitude 3.9, it is 11 times the Sun's width and more than 50 times as luminous



△ **M44**
Only 600 million years old, M44 (also known as the Beehive Cluster or Praesepe) is a relatively loose group of young stars spread across an area of sky three times the size of the Full Moon. It is visible to the naked eye as a starry swarm, and binoculars reveal individual stars of 6th magnitude or fainter. At 590 light-years away, it is one of the closest open clusters to Earth.



Assellus Borealis (γ Cancri)
A white subgiant a little over twice the Sun's mass and width, and 35 times its luminosity

Acubens (α Cancri)
Two white main-sequence stars with two red dwarf stars close by, but seen as a single star by the naked eye

Altarf (β Cancri)
Cancer's brightest star, an orange giant, 50 times the width of the Sun. It has a distant and faint red dwarf companion